Quadreria
STUDIO

Five Costly Mistakes Founders Make Before Their First Sample

(AND HOW TO AVOID THEM)

A SHORT GUIDE FOR FOUNDERS PREPARING FOR THEIR FIRST SAMPLE.

Five Costly Mistakes Founders Make Before Their First Sample

Most of the money founders lose in fashion isn't lost in production. It's lost earlier, in the weeks before the first sample is even made. By the time a founder comes to us after a bad sampling round, the damage is usually already done: money spent, time gone, and a sample that looks nothing like what they pictured.

The frustrating part is that almost all of it is avoidable. We see these mistakes come up again and again in discovery calls, and none of them are about bad taste. They're about skipping steps that feel optional but aren't.

So here are the five we see most often.

01 Walking into a factory with screenshots instead of specs.

A Pinterest board is a great starting point, but it isn't a brief a manufacturer can work from. When you hand over reference images, the factory fills every gap with its own assumptions: fit, fabric weight, stitching, finishing. You won't find out what they assumed until the sample arrives. A reference shows the feeling you want. A spec shows the garment you want. You need both.

02 Skipping the tech pack to save money.

We understand the instinct. A tech pack can feel like paperwork when you just want to see your product. But a sample made without one almost always needs a second round, sometimes a third, and each round costs more than the tech pack would have. It's also the only document that protects you if the bulk order doesn't match the approved sample.

03 Choosing fabric by how it looks in a photo.

Two fabrics can look identical on screen and behave completely differently on the body. Weight (GSM), stretch, shrinkage after washing, and the vendor's minimum order quantity all change the final garment and its cost. Ask for swatches, feel them, wash them, and only then decide.

04 Leaving fit for later.

Fit is the one thing customers notice instantly and forgive the least. Many founders lock in the design and only think about measurements once the sample is on the table. By then, fixing fit means reworking the pattern. Decide your size chart and your ideal fit (relaxed, regular, oversized) before sampling, not after.

05 Budgeting for only one sample round.

The first sample is rarely the final sample. That's not failure, it's the process. Plan for at least two rounds in both your budget and your timeline. Founders who expect one round end up rushing approvals or launching late. Founders who plan for two make better decisions with less stress.

None of these mistakes mean a founder isn't serious. They usually mean nobody walked them through the process before they started spending. That's the part of the journey we enjoy most: taking a raw idea and building the structure around it, so your first sample is a step forward and not a costly lesson.

If you're about to approach a manufacturer and something here felt familiar, it's worth a conversation before you send anything out.

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